



Evacuating Dunkirk

A total of 693 ships rescued 340,000 British and French troops, such as those stranded on the beach above, from the northern French port of Dunkirk. The British people sailed their own fishing boats across the English Channel to support the Royal Navy's fleet. Churchill described the event as a "miracle of deliverance."

advanced to Abbeville, on the north French coast, trapping British and French forces. The French begged the British for more military support, but the British Prime Minister, Winston Churchill, persuaded that France was lost, kept forces in reserve to protect Britain from German attack. From May 27 to June 4, Allied troops were evacuated from Dunkirk.

On June 22, 1940, it seemed that Germany had all but won. In an act of revenge, Hitler forced France to sign an armistice (peace agreement) in the same railroad car where the terms of Germany's defeat were agreed at the end of World War I (see pp.372–75). Hitler's popularity in Germany reached new heights. Each German offensive had achieved victory, and for many



SPITFIRE MK V

Air power

RAF Fighter Command had a numerical advantage over the German fighter force for most of the Battle of Britain. The British built 1,900 fighter planes, such as this Spitfire, the Germans built only 775.

German citizens, untouched by war in their homeland, the process was easy.

Turning points

The Battle of Britain was waged from August to October 1940, and proved to be a turning point in Hitler's fortunes. The battle, fought by air, was intended as a prelude to German invasion. The *Luftwaffe* targeted airfields and ports along the English Channel, but the Royal Air Force's (RAF) early warning systems gave Britain the advantage. Hitler abandoned "Operation Sealion," his invasion plan, and began to target British cities instead (see left).

Perhaps if Hitler had consolidated his gains in Western Europe, Germany might have been victorious. But Hitler chose to invade Russia. Stalin's demand that Romania return Bessarabia to Russia, and his annexing of the Baltic States in 1940, infuriated Hitler. By

1941, Germany and its allies had overrun Yugoslavia and Greece, and with Romania, Hungary, and Slovakia in support, Hitler was confident of a broad front for the attack. In June 1941, Germany invaded Russia. Initially, the campaign, "Operation Barbarossa," made rapid advances, but the Soviet Red Army and a bitter Russian winter put paid to *blitzkrieg* tactics. Long battles ensued, some lasting many months, with enormous suffering and loss of life on both sides. In August 1942 a fierce battle began at Stalingrad (see p.394), which resulted in a German defeat. The tide of war had begun to turn.

BRITISH PRIME MINISTER (1874–1965)

WINSTON CHURCHILL

Born into the British aristocracy, Winston Churchill joined the army in his youth and served with the 4th Queen's Own Hussars, which gave him valuable firsthand knowledge of war. He entered parliament in 1899, holding many posts, including Secretary of State for War during World War I. As British Prime Minister (1940–45 and again in 1951–55) he resisted calls to settle a peace with Hitler, insisting that Britain should go down fighting. He is famous for his pugnacious war leadership and brilliant oratory. He was a prolific writer and was awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature for his book *The Second World War*.



The Axis in Europe

The alliance between Nazi Germany, Fascist Italy, and later Japan was known as the Axis. It was formalized in the Tripartite Treaty signed in 1940. Other minor powers became Axis satellites, supporting Germany's war aims.

AFTER

In France, the government collaborated with the Nazis, but here, as throughout occupied Europe, resistance movements formed.

VICHY FRANCE

After France's defeat **Marshal Pétain** took control of the French Government and agreed to the division of France into an **occupied zone** and a **nonoccupied Vichy zone**. Vichy France was administered by the French Government under Pétain, on condition of full collaboration with the Germans. Pétain sympathized with Nazi ideology. He replaced France's motto of "Liberty, Equality, Fraternity" with "Work, Family, Fatherland," and formed a militia that sent French Jews to die in Nazi concentration camps.

FIGHTING BACK

Resistance movements rose up against the Nazis all over occupied Europe. The *Maquis*, a French organization, attacked German installations and helped stranded British airmen. In Poland, partisans blew up bridges to stop German supplies from reaching battle zones. In Yugoslavia, **communist partisans** were led by **Josef Tito** 450 », who narrowly escaped capture to go on and lead the country after the war.

TITO'S PARTISANS



KEY

- Frontiers, 1937
- Frontiers, Nov 1942
- Greater German Reich
- German occupation
- Italian territory
- Axis satellite
- Finnish territory
- Neutral
- Allied territory
- Allied occupation, 1941

